

Mexico '86, Marx and the Hand of God

How a symbol makes a price and an enemy in the same gesture

*divide everything — a flag or a number — make 'em opposites,
so there's a reason... ok now we can fight*
— Stereolab, "Les Yper-Sound" (1994)

Three days before Argentina played England, an AFA administrator named Rubén Moschella was working the sports shops of Mexico City with an errand that sounded like a prank: *hello, I'm with the Argentine national team — do you stock Le Coq Sportif, in blue?* It had to be Le Coq, logo and all: the team was bound to the brand, so just any blue shirt would not pass. Bilardo, who ran his life on superstition, refused to wear the blue set they'd beaten Uruguay in. The reason he gave was that it was too heavy — though nothing guaranteed a hastily sourced replacement would be any lighter; the switch was ritual, not material. Le Coq Sportif couldn't run a fresh set in seventy-two hours either. So the alternative kit for the most mythologised match in football history would be whatever of the brand's own retail stock a man could pull off a shelf. He came back with two: both blue, both Le Coq — they had to be — though neither the team's official perforated kit, just shop stock off a Mexico City shelf.

Bilardo wasn't sold. And here is the instant everyone repeats as folklore and nobody reads for what it is. With the coach stalling, the decision went not to a committee but to Maradona — and not as *do you like this one?* but as *which one do you like?* That is not a small edit. "Do you like it?" leaves room for a no. "Which do you like?" has already pocketed the yes; it strikes refusal from the menu and leaves only preference. Diego looked, felt the cloth, and ruled: *qué linda esta camiseta — con ésta le ganamos a los ingleses*. The framing of the choice manufactured a conviction, and the conviction manufactured a talisman, before a thread had touched the grass. Choice architecture by instinct, in a hotel corridor.

The surface gets told a hundred times: a Club América designer sketching the AFA crest in a rush and forgetting the laurels around it; women stitching the improvised badge by hand; silver American-football numbers ironed on against the clock. Good folklore. The thing standing behind it is plainer and stranger. That shirt — bought in a panic, picked for its looks — later sold for £7.14 million at Sotheby's. A knockoff of it costs a few pounds; even Le Coq's own official reissue runs about £150 — and that reissue cannot wear the Argentina crest, because the licence now belongs to adidas. You cannot buy the same object: the cheap one is a fake, and the legitimate one is legally barred from being identical. Even the seal of sameness is held by someone else.

And which "real" shirt it is took a forensic ruling to settle. Maradona wore a different

shirt in each half against England; both goals came in the second. For years his family insisted they held the genuine one and that Hodge had only a lesser half. Before the 2022 sale, a photomatch — micro-creases, stray threads and the exact set of the crest checked frame by frame against the match film — certified that Hodge’s was the second-half shirt, the shirt of both goals (Hughson & Moore, 2012). The aura had to be confirmed by camera; the relic’s realness was a verdict, not a property of the cloth.

So where do the other seven million live? Not in the thread, not in the labour, not in the factory. The favourite way to put it is that the shirt “refutes Marx” — value is subjective, a Van Gogh beats an airliner though it took fewer hours to make. But that aims at a claim Marx never made: he placed non-reproducible things — art, relics, the unique — *outside* the labour theory of value on purpose, as carrying a monopoly price set by desire, not by labour-time. Whether the theory holds for ordinary, reproducible goods is a live argument — some find the correlations strikingly high, others call them spurious — but the relic never enters that fight. It is the exception, not the refutation. What the shirt actually shows is narrower and harder: value can be pure story, welded to an object that did nothing to earn it.

The story is a war, and Maradona never hid it. To the flag, his account was vengeance — beating England meant recovering a small piece of the Malvinas, payment for boys who hadn’t come back. But to the men he was generous: he called the English players gentlemen, refused to blame them, said the goal of the century could only have been scored against a side that played fair. Two voices in one mouth. The enemy was the *symbol*, not the human across from him — whom he respected. The flag makes the enemy; the man, up close, never was one. And the enemy, once drawn, is needed: a side exists only against another, like Hegel’s master and his slave, each fixed by the one it means to beat — so the division outlives the reason that made it, and choosing a team starts to feel like a way of existing.

That is the whole gesture. A symbol divides: it lifts an object out of the world and makes it priceless, and in the same motion it lifts a quarrel out of the world and makes men expendable for it. Elvis Costello caught the second half in *Shipbuilding* — the Falklands seen from the dockyards, where the war that will kill your sons is also what reopens the yard that feeds them, the working class on both sides paying in bodies for a fight settled far above their heads. Both countries sent their poorest to the South Atlantic and got back names on a wall. The shirt and the dead issue from the same operation.

That’s the observation. The shirt is just the cleanest specimen — a £150 rag turned to seven million because a story passed through it, the way a flag becomes worth dying for because a story passed through that. The price and the enemy are made in the same gesture. And both are paid by the same people.

Sources

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